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How to design out obsolescence in fashion? - exploring wardrobe methods as a strategy in design education

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Abstract:
The paper presents a case study of four DSKD graduates who have actively chosen to implement and experiment with wardrobe methods in their design practice as a way to further garment longevity and encourage more sustainable lifestyles. In the paper we first explore examples of how these methods impact the design process, the design outcome and the designer role when applied in practice. Second, we discuss how, designers' engagement with and understanding of users' real lived clothing practices may lessen product obsolescence in relation to fashion. Through this study we suggest that designers can help users build 'clothing competencies', as part of a design practice. They not only aim to design products for longevity, but also apply a design process that assist users to enjoy and keep their garments in active use over time. These design interventions help the user build self-reliance and understanding of personal needs in terms of style and function starting from what's in their wardrobe. The cases show how wardrobe methods, when applied to design practice can divert in multifarious ways and help design out fashion obsolescence.

Introduction

Industrial mass production of textiles in the middle of the 19th century, created the basis for turning fashion making into a trend-based practice by offering new collections of decorated fabrics twice a year (Forty,1992; Harris, 1993). From the 1960s outsourcing of the fashion industry developed into a global system, and with the raise of fast fashion around 2000 a new norm of planned obsolescence was established that replaces garments with an ever-increasing high speed (Bismar, 2015; Fletcher, 2012). This development has had huge environmental consequences and also influenced fashion and textile education as well as the profession in general.

In Denmark fashion design education was established in 1967 to meet new needs in the growing industry. As in most western countries this education started out teaching trend development visualized in mood boards (Delong & Labat, 2004; Casedy, 2011), and described as personas, 'universes and muses based on presumptions of what and who fashion users wants to be. Such imaginary constructions of the user as consumer are strongly supported by the fashion media presenting 'dream concepts' of fast fashion as a 'democratic right' for the masses (Woodward, 2007; Skjold, 2015; Valle-Noronha, 2019).

As product obsolescence mechanisms are evidently unviable in terms of planetary boundaries and sustainability, the entire sector is currently looking to change. However, the Pulse of the fashion industry report (2019) states," … that fashion companies are not implementing sustainable solutions fast enough to counterbalance negative environmental and social impacts of the rapidly growing fashion industry" (p. 4). Niinimäki et al. (2020) find that "…brands are now producing almost twice the number of clothing collections compared with pre-2000, when fast-fashion phenomena started" (p.189). This clearly demonstrates that planned obsolescence is still the norm within the industry. In order to change this, alternatives must be developed that can meet the 'fashion' needs of the users. New understandings of what fashion might be and what value criteria we assign to this has to be developed and transformed into new business models.

Therefore, more fundamental shifts in approaches to fashion design and fashion use are needed. Here, designers and their education can contribute by replacing drivers of

the fast fashion system (Rissanen, 2017; FashionSEEDS, 2018; Ræbild & Riisberg, 2021). To initiate such changes design students must be given relevant knowledge, methods and tools to gain experiences with new ways of doing, whereby product obsolescence can be designed out (or lessened) in fashion. This, we believe, entail dialogue and engagement with users in order to build clothing competences that can support transition to a more healthy and sustainable fashion culture. Fletchers refers to the notion 'clothing competence' developed by Tranberg Hansen as a "set of skills, ideas, and identifiable practices that are conducive to promoting the satisfying use of garments and to the creation of fluid appearance in dress appropriate to both time and place that is expressed in a fashion 'moment'." (Fletcher, 2012 p. 235).

Wardrobe studies

At Design School Kolding (DSKD) we have introduced, developed and applied wardrobe studies at BA and MA level since 2012. Klepp and Bjerck (2012) define wardrobe studies as "…a methodological approach that analyses the way in which clothes relate to each other on the whole or in parts of the wardrobe" (p. 373). Research, in this field has shown, that while companies churn out new products at certain intervals in a linear manner, the way people manage, organise, buy and discard their clothes are non-linear and complex. In fact, whilst people may be influenced by trends, the main drivers for using, keeping or discarding clothes items are personal (Klepp & Bjerck, 2012; Fletcher, 2016; Skjold, 2016; Fletcher & Klepp, 2017).

This paper first explores examples of how these methods impact the design process, the design outcome and the designer role when applied in practice. Second, the paper discusses how, designers' engagement with and understanding of users' real lived clothing practices may lessen product obsolescence in relation to fashion.

Methodology

The paper presents a case study (Crouch & Pearce 2012) of four designers conducted spring 2021. The case designers graduated from DSKD in the period 2003 - 2020. All four have actively chosen in different ways to implement and experiment with wardrobe methods in their design practice as a way to further garment longevity and encourage more sustainable lifestyles.

The empirical material consists of semi-structured interviews (Leavy & Brinkmann, 2014) conducted online, the case designers´ projects, including descriptions, presentations, and website information.

In the paper we analyse the four cases using a wardrobe method typology 'The Family Tree of Wardrobe Methods' by Fletcher & Klepp (2017) to uncover the types of user engagements and motivations embedded in the designer's work. The concluding discussion is centred around the notion of *clothing competence* as coined by Tranberg Hansen (2003) and further explored by Fletcher (2012).

Wardrobe methods in practice

Case 1

Signe Brøchner (SB) and Ashna Patel (AP), graduated from the interdisciplinary MA programme in design and sustainability, Design for Planet, in 2020. They both came to the MA with a menswear design expertise from their BA studies, AP from London College of Fashion, and SB from DSKD. For SB, wardrobe methods had been introduced in curriculum during her third year BA. For AP, wardrobe methods and user driven approaches in fashion, was new.

During their final year they worked together in the project *Dear men of Midddelfart* within the course Design for Behavioural Change. The brief was about green transition through design-led co-creation with citizens in small Danish towns, here specifically the commune and residents of Middelfart. The two designers asked. " What if men felt empowered to sustain attachments to their garments, and what if we could co-create a community space for this purpose?"

In order to explore these questions, they devised a *portable wardrobe studies* dialogue tool (Figure 1).

In their first set of workshops, the designers met with the residents who answered the invitation. They first spent time with them individually in order to understand the men's relationship with garments. Secondly, the designers created a visual dialogue tool to engage the men in a tangible activity inspired by wardrobe studies. From these interactions SB and AP gained

insights on how and where the men buy clothes, how they establish and maintain relationships with the clothes and how and why they chose to dispose of them.



Figure 1. Portable Wardrobe Studies Dialogue Tool. Photo credit Ashna Patel & Signe Brøchner (2020).

When we look at the activities in relation to the wardrobe methods typology (Fletcher & Klepp, 2017), we can see, that the designers draw on *participatory* wardrobe methods, because participants "also contribute with words, sounds or images about their own clothing practices" (ibid p. 177). But also *wardrobe activism*, where the researcher's role is often "that of facilitator, sometimes teacher and documenter of what takes place" (ibid p. 185). The distinctive feature of this method is the gathering of data through a creative activity to gain insights about the use phase. AP and SB invite and engage the men to co-explore their own clothing practices and thereby help build participants own understanding of it.

Case 2

Amalie Ask (AA) graduated in 2018 with an MA in Fashion Design. Since graduation, AA has worked for Danish designer Jan Machenhauer who is renowned for his product durability ideology. The first year as a design student AA attended industrial design where she was introduced to user studies. Shifting to fashion in her second year, she wondered about the lack of user involvement in the design process. However, later she was introduced to wardrobe methods during the final year of her BA studies in the course Design for Change (Ræbild & Riisberg, 2018). Inspired by Woodward (2007) AA decided to apply wardrobe methods as a user driven approach in her MA thesis. During this project she explored what she experienced as a conflict area in outer wear between fashion aesthetics and garment functionally. This she investigated through wardrobe interviews with women representing her selected target group.

She conducted interviews with three women age 25-32, focusing on their use of outer wear garments. AA found out, that it meant more to them to feel stylish than to be kept warm and dry. For example, the women explained how they would rather be soaked than to wear a rain coat. AA also obtained insights on how the women 'felt silly' in hoods, and how oftentimes the cut of the garment made them feel bulky. AA also found out, that it was small details that made a garment feel to 'outdoorsy' or sporty to their liking. AA film recorded the wardrobe interviews and used the observations during her design ideation and toile making process. When the collection was finalized, she brought the garments to the women's homes where they tried them out, and gave comments while they mixed and matched the outerwear with their own garments.

As part of the design concept AA described a potential future business concept where the collection is designed, showcased and produced in facilities close to the costumer in combination with guidance on materials, fit and possibilities for layering garments before purchase via web shop.

Looking back on the project, AA reflects on how she struggled as a designer between being loyal to the women's opinions and tastes while staying true to her own aesthetic language. She says, that should she work actively with wardrobe interviews now, she would let them inform her process, but not let them decide the final outcome, if she didn't like it herself.

In this case we see AA employ wardrobe interviews which, according to the wardrobe typology, "is a method where specific garments and/or clothing related behaviours act as a

'gateway' to opening up the wardrobe". (Fletcher & Klepp, 2017, p.173).

Case 3

Laura Terkildsen (LT) graduated with an MA in textile design in 2005, before wardrobe methods became part of DSKD curriculum. Her first job was as knit designer including forecasting. Next, she worked as shop assistant in a womenswear boutique selling large size garments and then moved on to become personal shopping assistant in a department store for a number of years. At the same time, she took classes at the university in Art History and in 2015 during a course in Ethnography she discovered Woodward's writings on wardrobe studies. Here LT found theory that connected the wearer, garments and use, perspectives which she had been missing in design education. LT found the job as shopping assistant interesting due to the dialogue with many different customers and her design competencies turned out useful in finding the right garments, however, she was not so interested in the sales part. Therefore, she decided to set up her own business in 2017 focusing on how to guide women in styling what they already have and avoid buying mistakes. LT call herself a wardrobe expert and sees her practice as part of promoting more sustainable consumption patterns. She loves to help women become confident and happy about everyday dressing by developing skills and a library of clothes that provides overview. The methods she uses has developed through practice with women trying on clothes in the fitting room of the department store and later in her own business. To make a maximum of outfits from what is already in the wardrobe she works with the interaction between garment shape, textile material, colour, contrast, pattern, texture and the body to create a united composition, drawing on basic skills from her design education.

LT has developed a set of 'assignments' that the clients are asked to do before she visits them. First, they have to sort and to try on all garments with open and closed eyes in order to see colour, patterns, shape, feel the fit and sense the materials on the body. Then they have to pick out the clothes that will fit if they gain or lose weight, that is the '5 kg pile'. Next, they are asked to make a 'nostalgia' pile with clothes they do not wear but still feel emotionally attached to. They are asked to consider getting rid of it, put it in storage and maybe keep one piece they can hang on the wall. The last pile is the 'wrong purchase' pile, when done it should be carefully analysed to find out if there is a pattern – what is it I repeat and is there some kind of dream image involved? What remains should be the 'yeah' pile representing what fits and what they actually like to wear.



Figure 2. LT at work in a client's Wardrobe. Photo credit Laura Terkildsen (2020).

Next step is a visit to their home, where LT make a personal interview to understand client's self-image, needs, dreams, aspirations and life situation e.g., if they bicycle to work, dress code in the job and how body temperature may fluctuate during the day or if they are always cold or warm. She then asks the client to pull out everything from the 'yeah' pile and try out various combinations of clothes that LT suggests related to categories like sporty, casual and feminine. During this session she takes pictures that serve as illustrations in a follow up text. She also encourages them to take selfies so they can learn more about how to experiment with combinations on their own. Her focus is on building client's own self-reliance when it comes to clothing choices. Not to provide a set of expert rules.

LT talks about the 'whauu' experience the clients get when they are pleased with compositions matching their personality and how surprised they are when finding out the many new 'looks' they can make without buying new clothes. She also gives advice on adjusting some garments and if they are unable to do so themselves to take it to a service. LT says there is a need to relearn how to repair

and adjust clothes since these skills are no longer part of our upbringing or education. "Many shop too much – hoping to find solutions to other problems – comfort shopping like comfort eating".

This case shows a combination of several wardrobe methods; wardrobe interviews, wardrobe audits which is the "process of creating a systematic overview of the wardrobe" (ibid. p. 170) and wardrobe consultation where services "are directed at the wardrobe, not at purchases" (ibid. p. 187).

Concluding discussion

The first two cases show designers using wardrobe methods to inform their design practice, but at the same time, they also seek to educate and empower the user. Therefore, the wardrobe methods they either use and/or develop have an engaging character, with emphasis on building user awareness and clothing competences. The last case uses generic design competences in combination with wardrobe methods to activate private wardrobe 'deadstock' where new outfits are 'designed' and composed from existing garments while also providing clothing competences.

However, in what way might the wardrobe study-based practices, identified in the presented cases, be seen to design out fashion obsolescence?

In the *Dear men of Middelfart* project AP and SB used strategies to engage men through the wardrobe dialogue tool, in order to motivate participants to repair their own clothes, thereby prolonging the life of treasured garments.

Through wardrobe interviews AA sought insights on how to design outerwear that the women felt comfortable and stylish to wear and use. Thus, a focus on product satisfaction, to lessen number of mistaken purchases.

In the case of LT, the aim is to minimize consumption of new clothes, and instead educate women on how to activate what they already have. Thereby hindering garment disposal and lessening fashion obsolescence. Fashion is then becoming more of a practiced skill than a trend, and such skills can make garments relevant for the user again.

This resonates with Tranberg Hansen and Fletcher's notion of 'clothing competence' as a user carried counter weight to product obsolescence.

Through this study we suggest that designers can help users build clothing competencies, as part of a design practice. They not only aim to design products for longevity, but also design in a way and with a process that assist users to enjoy and keep their garments in active use over time. These design interventions help the user build self-reliance and understanding of personal needs in terms of style and function starting from what's in their wardrobe.

The cases show how wardrobe methods, when applied to design practice can divert in multifarious ways and help design out fashion obsolescence.

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